WCAG Guidelines and Standards

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1 Part 1: Web Accessibility Principles (The POUR Framework)

WCAG 2.2 is organized around four foundational principles — *Perceivable, Operable, Understandable, Robust* — each of which subsumes a set of normative guidelines.

1.1 Principle 1 — Perceivable

Information and user interface components must be presentable to users in ways they can perceive.

- **1.1 Text Alternatives** — Provide text alternatives for any non-text content.
- **1.2 Time-based Media** — Provide alternatives for time-based media (captions, audio description).
- **1.3 Adaptable** — Create content that can be presented in different ways without losing structure.
- **1.4 Distinguishable** — Make it easier to see and hear content, including separating foreground from background.

1.2 Principle 2 — Operable

User interface components and navigation must be operable.

- **2.1 Keyboard Accessible** — Make all functionality available from a keyboard.
- **2.2 Enough Time** — Provide users enough time to read and use content.
- **2.3 Seizures and Physical Reactions** — Do not design content in a way that is known to cause seizures.
- **2.4 Navigable** — Provide ways to help users navigate, find content, and determine where they are.
- **2.5 Input Modalities** — Make it easier to operate functionality through various inputs beyond the keyboard.

1.3 Principle 3 — Understandable

Information and the operation of the user interface must be understandable.

- **3.1 Readable** — Make text content readable and understandable.
- **3.2 Predictable** — Make web pages appear and operate in predictable ways.
- **3.3 Input Assistance** — Help users avoid and correct mistakes.

1.4 Principle 4 — Robust

Content must be robust enough that it can be interpreted reliably by a wide variety of user agents, including assistive technologies.

- **4.1 Compatible** — Maximize compatibility with current and future user agents (note: *4.1.1 Parsing* was removed in WCAG 2.2).

2 Part 2: Compliance Levels and Conformance Framework

2.1 The Three Conformance Levels

Every success criterion in WCAG 2.2 is assigned one of three levels:

- **Level A** — Minimum baseline. Non-negotiable for any accessible system.
- **Level AA** — Standard target for most legal and procurement frameworks (e.g., EU EN 301 549, US Section 508, ADA-aligned policy).
- **Level AAA** — Enhanced, contextual conformance; not recommended as a blanket site-wide target.

2.2 The Five Conformance Requirements

WCAG 2.2 defines five conformance requirements:

1. **Conformance Level** — Fully satisfy all requirements of the chosen level.
2. **Full Pages** — Conformance applies to full web pages, not fragments.
3. **Complete Processes** — Every step in a multi-step process must conform.
4. **Only Accessibility-Supported Ways** — Use only accessibility-supported technologies.
5. **Non-Interference** — No content may interfere with the accessibility of other content.

3 Sources

https://www.w3.org/TR/2024/REC-WCAG22-20241212/